Yell-Oh! Girls Poetry Collection

By Vickie Nam (ed.)

Innocence by Debra Yoo (pg 153)

The first day of kindergarten.

The classroom, filled with happy children

A sea of blond and brown heads

And yes, one head of black.

Me.

I didn't care. I didn't notice.

But everyone else did.

INTRODUCTION

As young children, we don't understand race or skin color. We assume everyone is the same. In fact, as a child I remember telling my mother that I was vanilla and my best friend was chocolate – as if the race issue was as simple as flavors of ice cream. If only this were so. Unfortunately, once society imposes itself on our view of the world, there comes an almost earth-shattering moment when we realize race is much more complex and divisive than flavored ice cream. Poems from Yell-Oh! Girls edited by Vickie Nam

FOR EDUCATIONAL

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I walk in the classroom.

Whispers follow, buzzing with gossip.

Secrets float from child to child.

I tensed, everyone was looking

At me.

They stared. I stared back.

Why was everyone watching me?

I see a boy about my age.

Pulling his eyes at the corners.

Making them sharp and pointed.

I realized, he was making fun

Of me.

But why? Because of my eyes?

I couldn't understand.

That first day was horrible.

Girls giggling, boys pointing.

No one who would be my friend.

I noticed, they were staying away

From me.

I almost cried. Tears sprang to my eyes.

But I kept my pride.

I boarded the bus for my ride home.

I felt safe, finally, at last.

Two boys sat in front of me.

They turned. "Chink," they said.

Me?

Chink? The word brought sadness to my soul.

Dejection crossed my face.

That first day hurt me.

Hurt my core, my only being.

But I finally realized.

People were prejudiced

Against me.

It came like a tidal wave. Smashed my spirit.

My eyes opened to the harsh world around me.

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TRANSITION

You see, racism isn't just black and white. – it's also Asian, Hispanic, and people of the Middle East. Today our focus is on Asian-Americans who struggle not only with the issue of race, but also culture. The blending of cultures is unique, significant and often cherished; but the beauty of a blended culture also can come with a burden . . . a burden of feeling as if you don't truly belong to either culture. Two by June Kim explores this cultural dichotomy.

Two by June Kim (pg 8)

Raised in two separate cultures

Growing up in a world with customs

Familiar at home and foreign in society

Reaching, roaring,

Rocking between things that surround

And lessons of a homeland farther away

Seeing crowds of endless faces different from your own

Hearing English words mixed with native tongues

Tasting foods loaded with thick flavor and warm spices

Scarlet passion

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Craving, calling
To accept a blend of opposites
To create an experience unique to you
A struggle to convey thoughts to those who cannot understand
Despite the
Searching
Studying what cannot be taught or red in lines

The experience that only comes from
Living, loving
Leaving one behind
The choice to abandon one completely for the other
Causing betrayal and ignorant hatred
Compulsions that wrench you violently from both sides
Fighting, fearing
Fitting into two places
Two cultures
Or maybe none.

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Untitled by Olivia Chung (pg 266)

At first glance, they looked at my face and prepared themselves in advance
For what kind of person I am, an ***Asian***.
I watched them uncomfortably guess my "original" nation.
Chinese? Japanese? Malaysian?
This is the overplayed scenario like the replayed songs on the radio,
Over and over like there ain't no end to it yo.

Since the first day of school I heard it.
Ching chong chinaman, chinky winky twinky
DO YOU SPEAK ENGLISHEE?
From the first moment, I felt it.
Can you really see through those eyes?
Oh how cute, two oriental girls. Are you twins?

I listened to their ignorant remakes as their sharp words ***pierced my heart.***

I allowed them to form my identity and tell me who I was.
Bruce Lee, Michelle Kwan, Yan Can Cook and so can you!
Because pigeonholed, it was all I was told.
Aren't you gonna be a doctor?
All Asians are good at science right?

So now you're thinking,
"What? Things like that don't happen to me. I hear no evil, I see no evil.hear no evil, see no
evil . . no evil."

You tell me you don't know what it means to be Asian, born and raised in a white nation, you're third generation,
"I've never *seen* discrimination."
I've read about Hitler and his evils of intended entire elimination of Jews.
I've heard about Rosa Parks with the blacks-at-the-back-of-the-bus laws — to obey, she
refused.

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But me . . . I've never *seen* discrimination,
never *felt* racial humiliation,
never *experienced* segregation.

So you know you're Asian if you leave your shoes at the front door.
That's your definition of tradition. You consider yourself Asian on this one condition!

I am who I am, I be who I be,
I am who I am, I be who I be
People will see me for me and award me for ability,
Praise me for attending ivy league,
Hire me for working so hard, so hopefully,
Holding onto a vision of my future reality . . .

But . . .

What if they fire me?
Look at Dr. Wen Ho Lee —
Maybe innocent, maybe guilty

Targeted unfairly 'cause of his ethnicity.
"You know dem chinese. They're either restaurant owners or spies."

I despise the lies seen in society's eyes.
See, even though
I am who I am and I be who I be
People ***can't*** see me for me.
That's the reality.

Can you hear the evil? Can you *see* the evil?
The sugarcane harvesters, sweatshop workers, picture brides, interned Japanese Americans . . . all the immigrants who came with high hopes seeking liberty stretching from sea to shining sea, singing my country 'tis of thee, sowing seed of strife in hopes of a better life . . . sacrifices and sweat, sacrifices and sweat, sacrifices and sweat, and sweat

These people faced persecution in the form of piercing painful prejudices pointing at them at every

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place . . . political pariahs, unable to speak their piece, unable to
speak peace.

That is why I get offended when you ask me where I'm really from.
That is why I fight for justice while obstacles continue to come.
That is why I call myself Asian American.
I am who I am, I be who I be
See me for me,
Then you'll get the reality.

Who is Singing This Song by Janice Mirikitani (pg xxxiii)

Who is singing this song?

I am.

pulled by hands of history to not sit
in these times, complacently,
walkmans plugged to our ears,

computers, soap operas lulling our passions to sleep.
We are required by legacies of grandparents, parents,
our enslaved and servant ancestors, our heroes and
sheroes,
our fighters for freedom, to be
now the storm of hands
that wave in protest against apartheid, racism, classism,
sexism
war, hate crime violence and indifference to the poor.

Who is singing this song?

I am.
We survive by hearing.
We speak to each other,
offering choices,
to love, to dream,

I DARE YOU,
dare you
to love, to dream . . .

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Who is singing this song?

I am.

You are.

Our music is beautiful.

SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

YALSA Outstanding Book Award